

Can Chinese EV brands compete in automotive trade media discourse?

A Semantic Brand Score comparison of BYD, Tesla, BMW, and Ford

Group 5:

Stanisław Wielgomas 52438

Wiktor Stanisławek 52593

Jakub Wojciechowski 49872

Antoni Hakizimana 52607

Brand focus

BYD

Chinese challenger

Tesla

Technological
disruptor

BMW

Premium legacy brand

Ford

Mass-market legacy
brand

Final project
March 2026

Semantic Brand Score
comparison deck

Executive summary

Established brands still dominate the discourse

Ford and BMW hold the strongest positions in the semantic space, outperforming the analysed Chinese brands in overall media presence and semantic strength.

Visibility does not equal centrality

A brand can appear in the discourse without becoming a central organizer of it. BYD is present, but it is still less connected than established incumbents.

BYD is the only Chinese brand with a meaningful foothold

Among the analysed Chinese brands, only BYD shows a clear and interpretable presence in the trade media discourse.

Business implication

Chinese challengers are entering the conversation, but established brands still own the broader and more connected narrative in automotive trade press.

Answer in brief: BYD is entering the conversation, but Ford and BMW still lead the broader semantic space.

Why this matters for the automotive industry

- Chinese EV brands are expanding internationally.
- Automotive competition is shaped not only by products, but also by media narratives.
- Trade media influence how industry actors interpret innovation, competition, and market leadership.

Hypothetical client

European automotive strategy / communications team

monitor emerging competitors
understand narrative positioning
adapt communication strategy

Competing in the automotive market increasingly means competing in the semantic space.

Can Chinese EV brands compete with established automotive leaders in automotive trade media discourse?

Which brands are the most visible?

Which brands have the richest semantic associations?

Which brands occupy the most central positions in the semantic network?

Data collection → Text processing → SBS analysis → Interpretation → Recommendations

Data

Source:

"motortrend.com", "caranddriver.com",
"autocar.co.uk", "autonews.com", "motor1.com"

Language: English

Time frame: 03.02.2026 - 05.02.2026

Articles collected: 534

Outlets included: 5

Coverage was intentionally limited to automotive trade press rather than general public news.

Method

Data collection via API and custom Python scripts

Cleaning, deduplication, and brand-based filtering

Text mining and co-occurrence analysis

Semantic Brand Score (SBS)

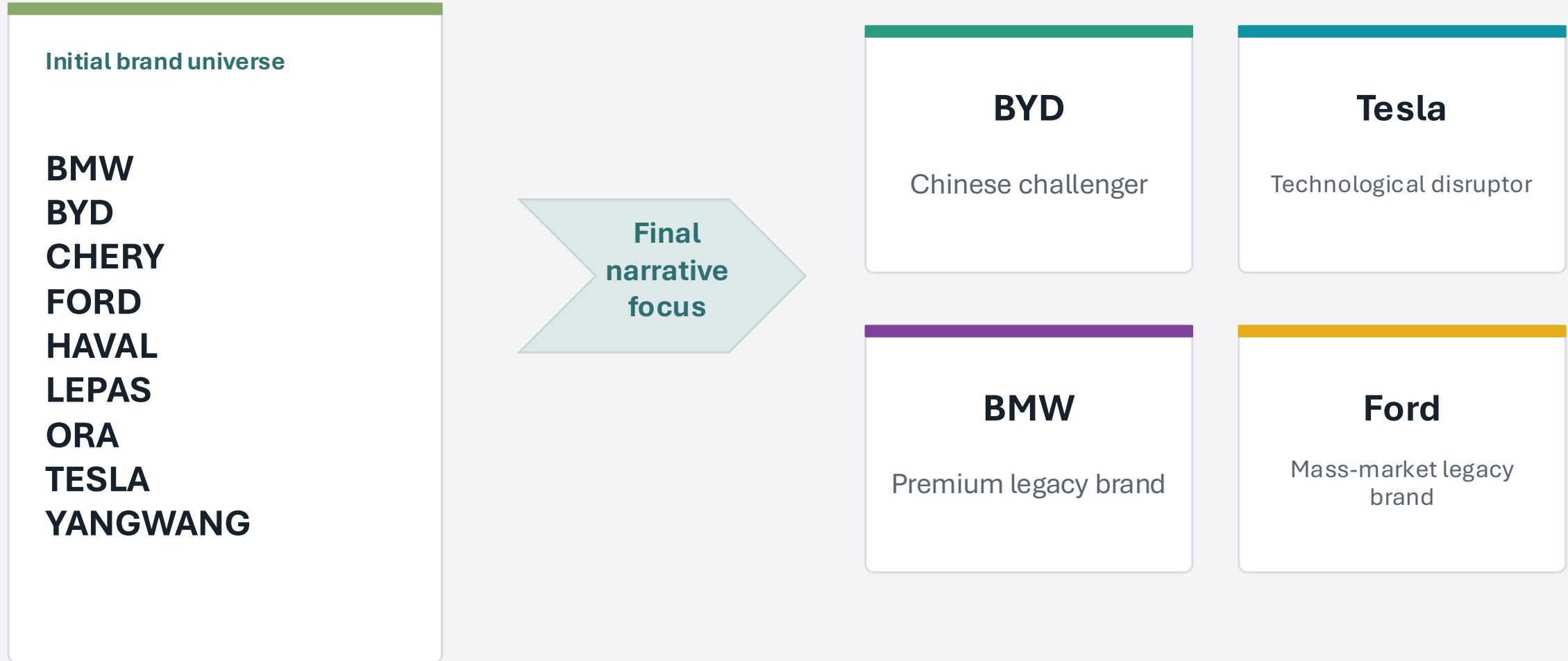
Comparison of prevalence, diversity, and connectivity

Pipeline: collect → clean → mine → score → compare

Main focal brands in the final comparison: BYD, Tesla, BMW, and Ford.

From broad brand screening to an interpretable comparison

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Other brands were retained only as exploratory background because their signal was too weak for a robust main comparison.

What Semantic Brand Score actually measures

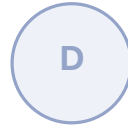
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Prevalence

How often a brand appears in the corpus.

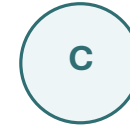
Plain meaning: visibility



Diversity

How many different associations surround the brand.

Plain meaning: narrative richness



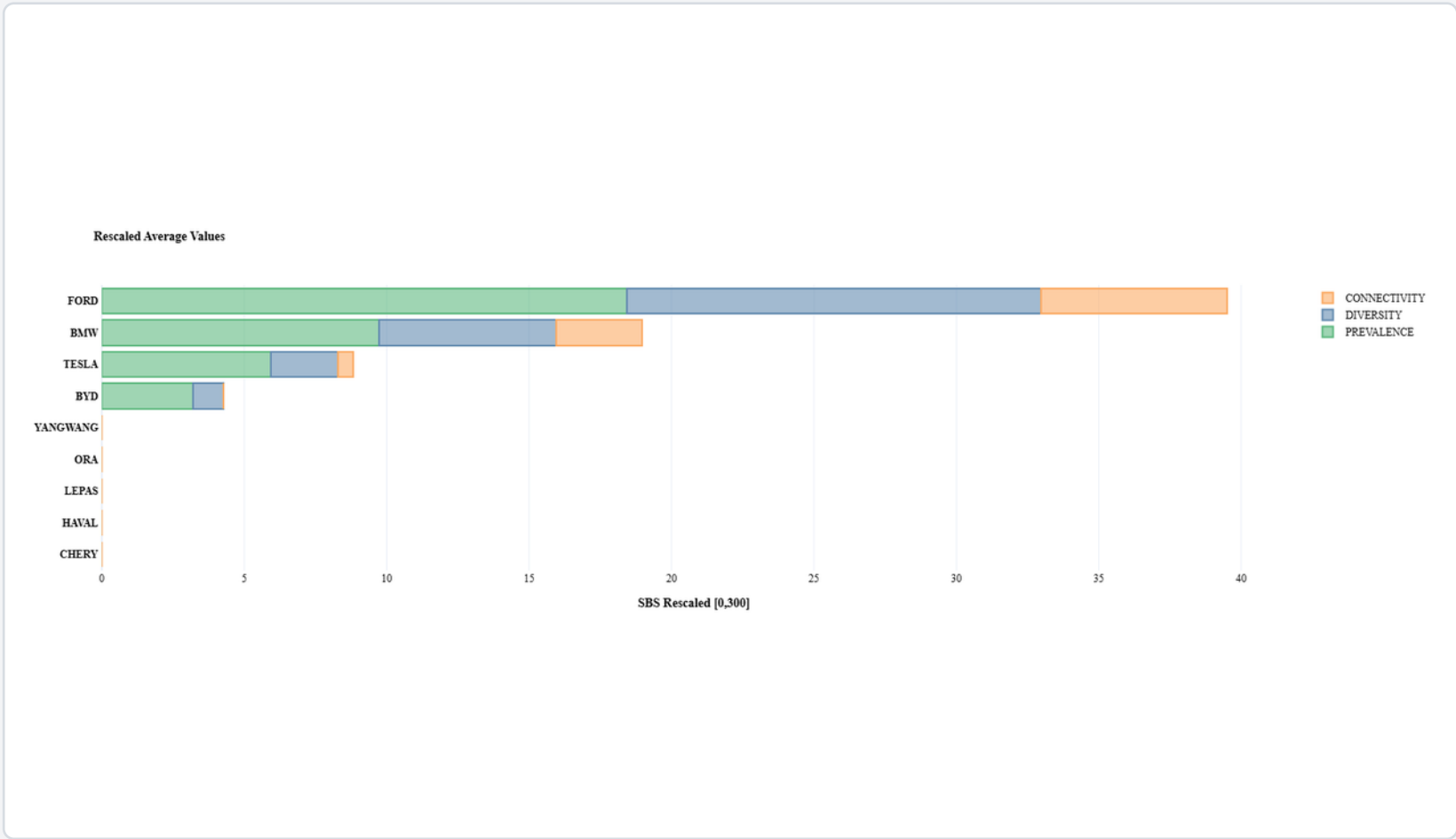
Connectivity

How central the brand is in the semantic network.

Plain meaning: network importance

A strong brand in semantic terms is not only frequently mentioned, but also broadly associated and centrally positioned.

Established brands dominate the semantic space



Ford shows the strongest overall semantic position.

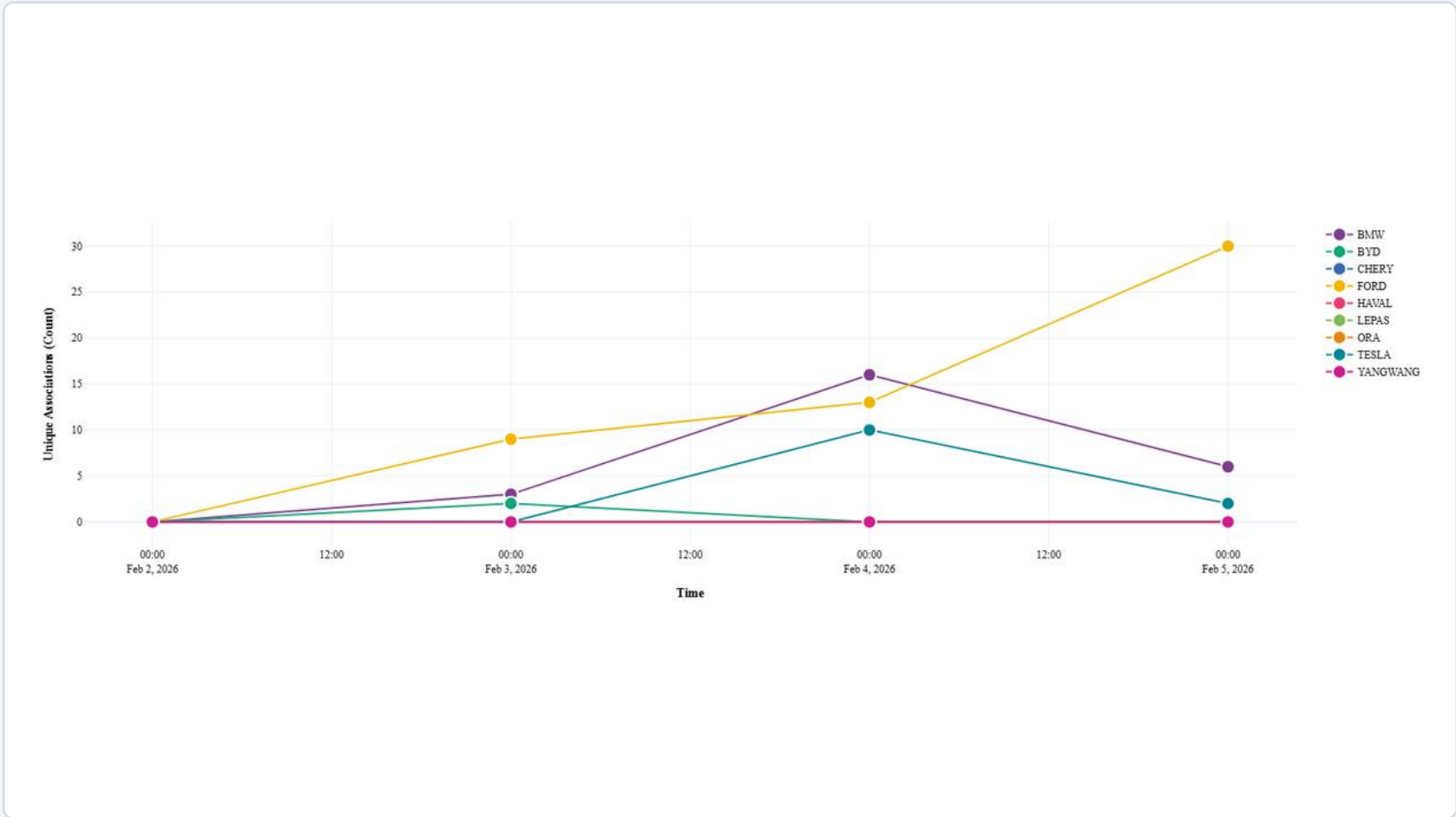
BMW also occupies a strong and stable position.

Tesla remains visible but does not dominate the discourse.

BYD is present, but still substantially weaker than the established leaders.

Overall SBS indicates that trade media discourse is still led by legacy brands rather than Chinese challengers.

Ford and BMW sustain richer semantic breadth over time



Ford develops the broadest and fastest-growing set of associations.

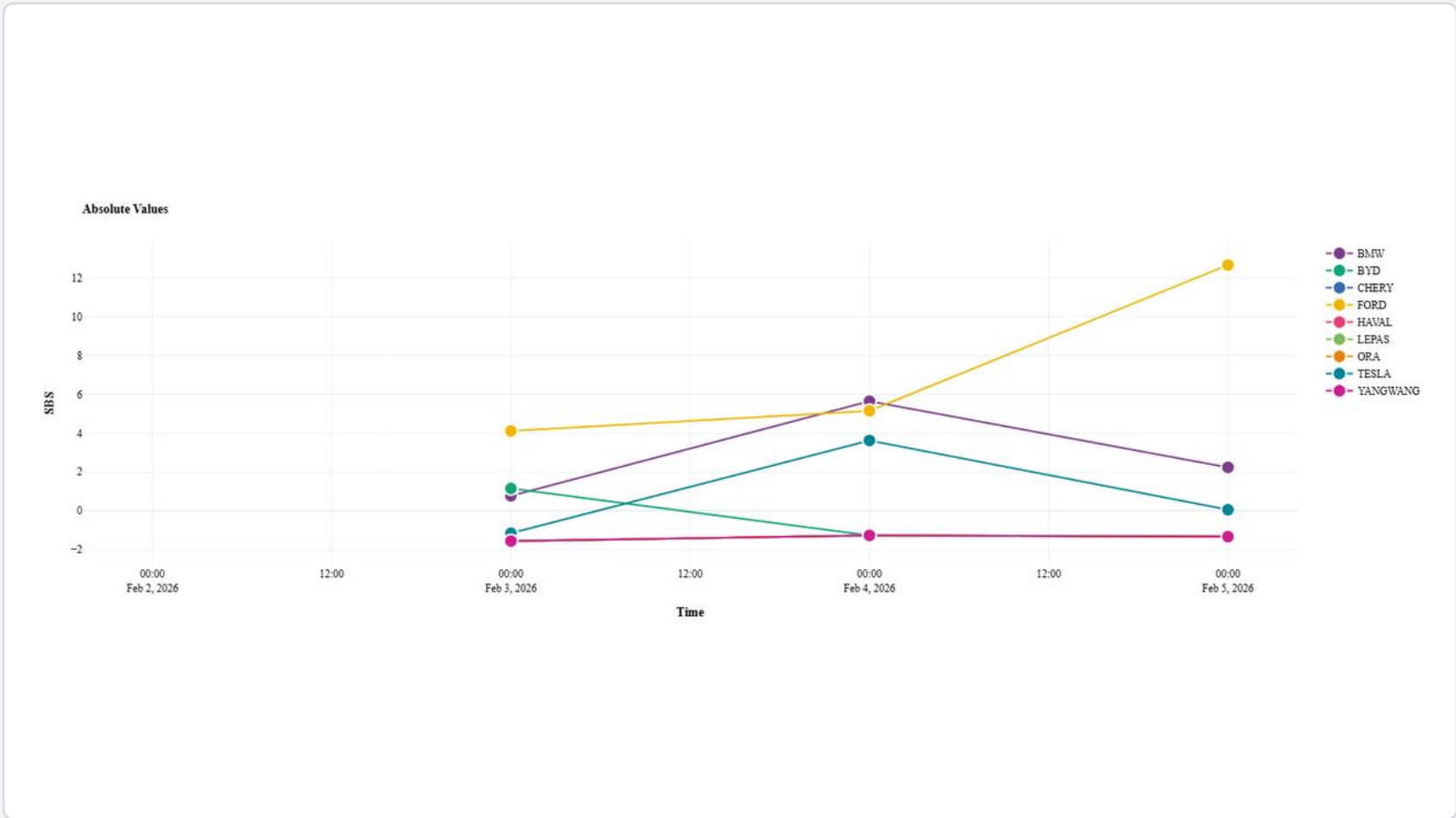
BMW reaches a strong peak, but its narrative breadth becomes less stable later.

Tesla shows meaningful but more limited narrative richness.

BYD remains weak and inconsistent in the variety of associated terms.

Unique associations highlight not only visibility, but also how wide and mature each brand’s surrounding narrative is.

BYD enters the discourse, but Ford and BMW remain stronger over time



Ford ends the period with the strongest SBS value.

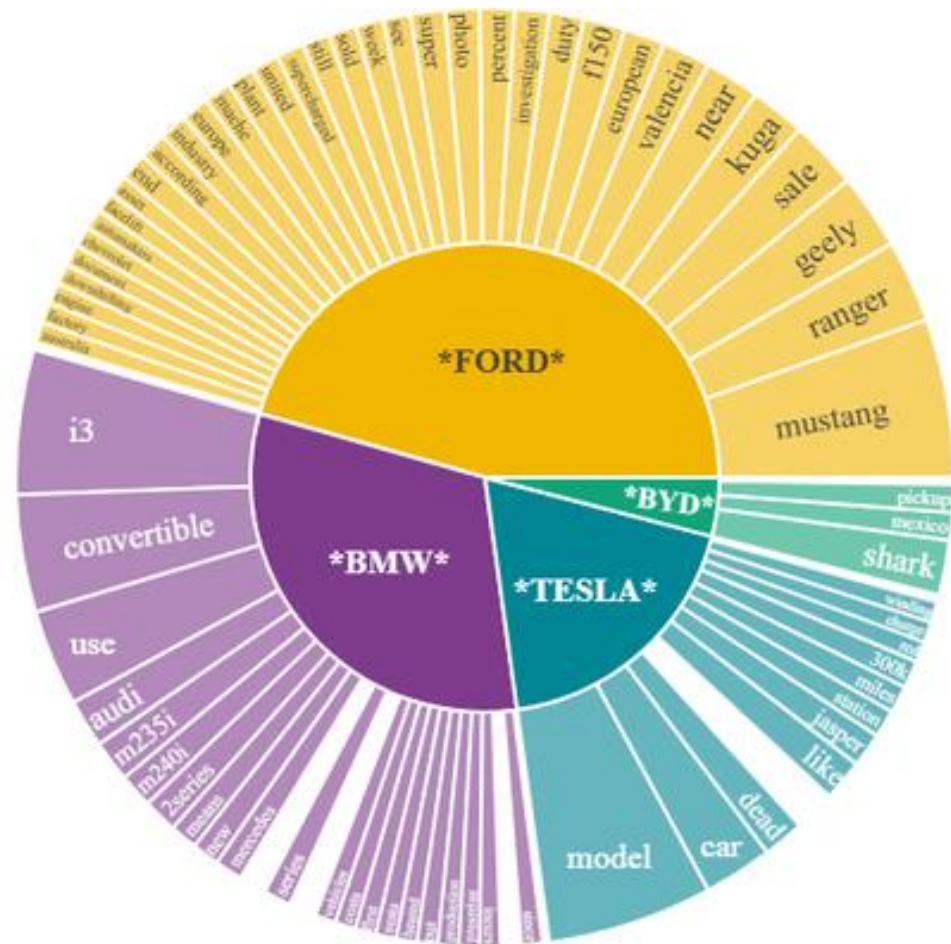
BMW records a strong mid-period peak but does not maintain it.

Tesla gains momentum temporarily, then weakens.

BYD appears in the discourse, but does not reach a sustained strong position.

Temporal SBS dynamics suggest that challenger visibility is emerging, but still not structurally sustained.

The four brands occupy clearly different semantic positions



Ford

Mustang, Ranger, sale

BMW

i3, convertible, use

Tesla

model, car, road

BYD

Shark, Mexico, pickup

Ford is linked to the broadest set of distinct brand-related terms, while BYD’s semantic field is narrower and more specific.

This comparison shows not only how much brands are discussed, but what kinds of meanings cluster around them.

What do the results mean?

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1. Legacy brands still dominate industry discourse

They are more visible, more richly associated, and more central in the semantic network than the Chinese brands in the analyzed corpus.

2. BYD is the only Chinese brand with a meaningful foothold

Among the analyzed Chinese brands, only BYD breaks through strongly enough to support an interpretable comparison with the leading incumbents.

3. Presence is not yet equal to narrative control

BYD appears in the conversation, but it does not yet structure or dominate the broader discourse in the way Ford and BMW do.

Answer to the research question: not yet fully — BYD is entering the conversation, but it does not yet control it.

For BYD and other challengers

- Increase presence in trade press beyond isolated launch coverage.
- Build broader associations around technology, long-term strategy, and market leadership.
- Aim for repeated visibility across time, not short-lived spikes.

For legacy brands

- Defend narrative leadership, not only market share.
- Keep innovation themes visible to avoid being framed as legacy-only players.
- Monitor challenger narratives early, before they become semantically central.

Limitations

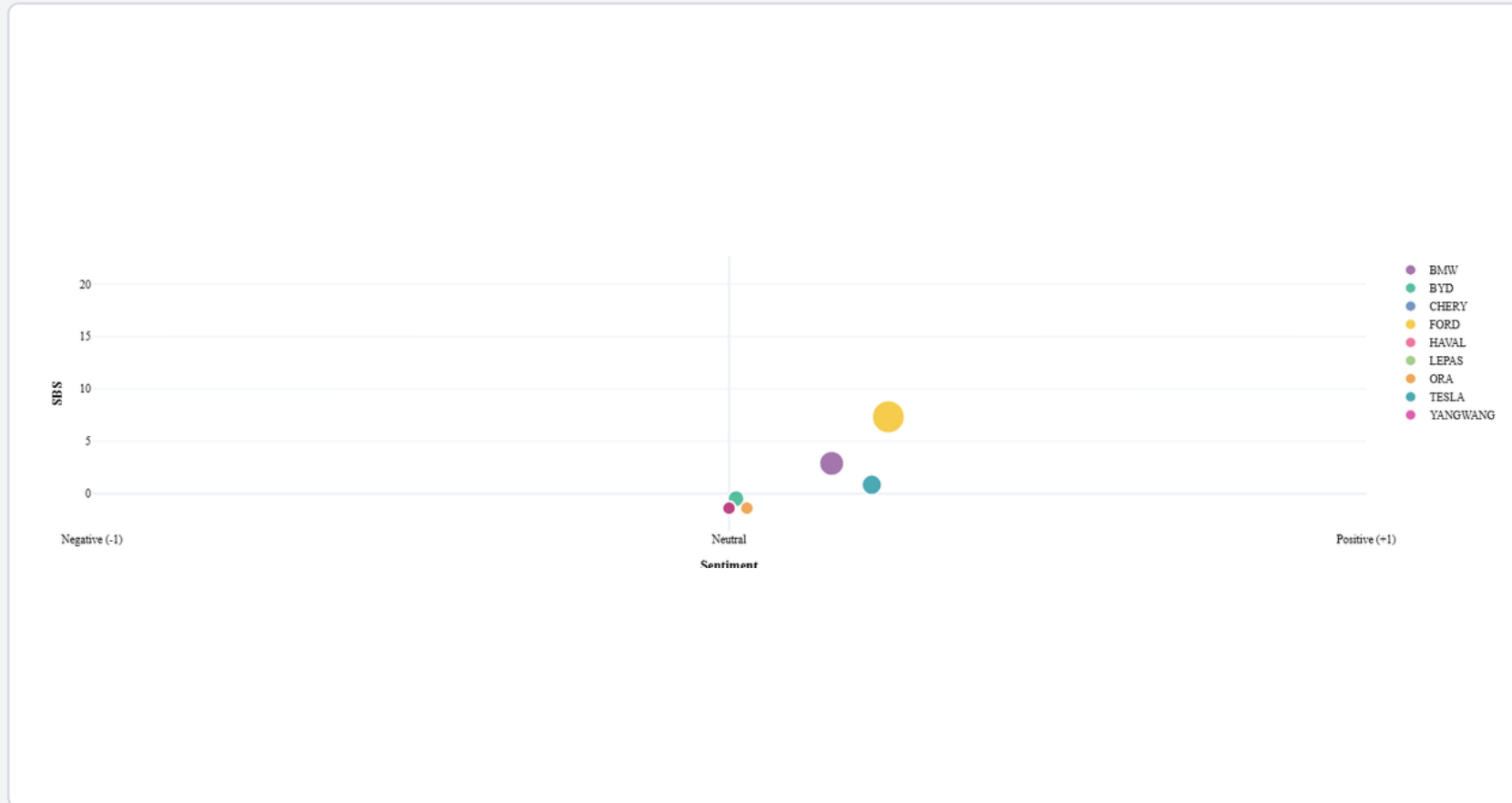
Selected automotive trade outlets only
Short time window
results reflect this corpus, not all media environments

Next steps

Extend the time frame
Add mainstream media and social media
Compare regions and markets over time

Appendix: semantic strength is not driven by sentiment alone

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The strongest brands cluster around near-neutral sentiment.

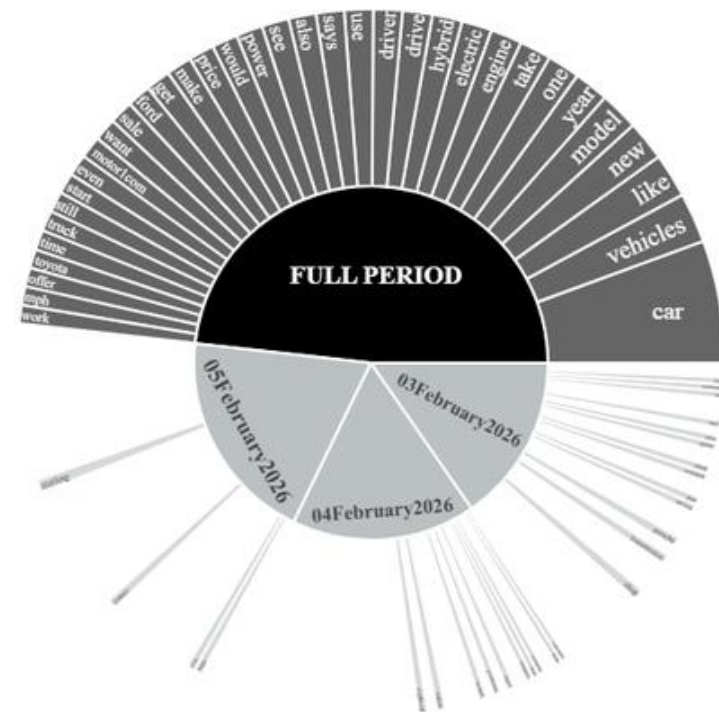
Higher SBS does not automatically mean more positive sentiment.

In this corpus, semantic dominance is better explained by visibility, breadth, and network position than by polarity alone.

This view supports the main findings, but it is not the core decision driver of the project.



Target words show that the corpus is dominated by broad automotive vocabulary such as car, sale, vehicles, hybrid, and engine.



The full-period structure confirms that the corpus is built around generic industry language, which is why brand-level differentiation must be interpreted carefully.

These views provide context for the main SBS comparison, but they are not the primary managerial takeaway.